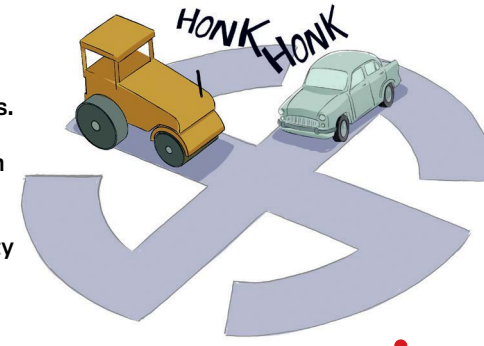
Power is an Optical Illusion

The ruling Bharat Rashtra Samiti (BRS) in Telangana is a picture of anxiety these days. It's seeing suspicious (and dangerous) similarities in the poll symbols allotted to other parties with its own 'car' symbol. And so, it has challenged the Election Commission's decision to allot 'road roller' and 'chapati roller' as symbols to the Yuga Thulasi Party and the Alliance of Democratic Reforms Party, respectively. The BRS, in fact, moved a special leave petition in the Supreme Court to the effect, in which it wanted the EC to be directed to delete symbols similar to theirs. Unfortunately, the SC has refused to entertain the petition and urged the BRS to trust the Indian electorate's ability to distinguish between a car, a rolling pin and a road roller. ■



SLIGHTLY BETTER PENSIONS?



Why be just a lowly mandarin when you can own the canton? Power exerts an irresistible pull on those within its gravitational field. No surprises, then, like always: a string of IAS-IPS types in Madhya Pradesh were eyeing tickets, keen on being the change they want to see. Early October, Shahdol divisional commissioner Rajeev Sharma quit the IAS to join politics, but was denied a BJP ticket. A couple of other ex-IASes were also ignored. Deputy collector Nisha Bangre may still get in, but the inordinate delay in the acceptance of her resignation may have put a Congress ticket out of reach for her. In Chhattisgarh, ex-babus have fared better. The BJP has fielded two, O.P. Chaudhry from Raigarh and Neelkanth Tekam from Keshkal. ■

Nepocracy Wins

What better way to ensure a constituency stays in the family than to contest from rival parties. And so brothers Girija Shankar Sharma and Sitasaran Sharma will be fighting for the Hoshangabad seat in Madhya Pradesh on Congress and BJP tickets, respectively. Both are BJP veterans and MLAs many times over. In neighbouring Timari seat, sitting BJP MLA Sanjay Shah is pitted against nephew Abhijit Shah (Congress). Another uncle-nephew battle will play out in Deotalab in Rewa district, where assembly speaker Girish Gautam will be pitted against nephew Padmesh Gautam (Congress). In Sagar, BJP MLA Shailendra Jain is contesting against his brother's wife Nidhi (Congress). In Akaltara seat in Chhattisgarh, Raghvendra Singh has Congress backing against uncle Saurabh Singh, the sitting BJP MLA. Thus political parties get to accommodate the rising ambitions of family members while fielding the charge of nepotism. Have your cake and eat it too. ■

in fact, figured in the first list of 52 candidates, prompting AIMIM chief and Hyderabad MP Asaduddin Owaisi to say, "Hate speech is the fastest way to get a promotion in Modi's BJP." Singh may have also forced the party's hand, by declaring he would contest as an independent if it didn't lift his suspension and nominate him. The man is also a Hindutva icon in these parts, threatening Navaratri celebration organisers in Hyderabad recently, asking them not to allow people of other faiths at dandiya dance venues. Wonder who's the real disruptor. ■

–By **Rohit Parihar, Amarnath K. Menon and Rahul Noronha**

